

The Noble Tantra Called 'Vajrapāṇi Wearing the Blue Garment: Taming the Three Worlds'

Ārya-Vajrapāṇi-nīlāmbara-dhara-triloka-vinaya-nāma-tantra · Toh 501 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་ལག་ན་རྩོམ་གྱིས་སྒྲོ་པ་ཅོན་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་འཇག་རྟེན་གསུ་འདུ་བའི་རྒྱ།

The Noble Tantra Called "Vajrapāṇi Wearing the Blue Garment: Taming the Three Worlds" is a Buddhist tantric scripture known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Vajrapāṇi-nīlāmbara-dhara-triloka-vinaya-nāma-tantra and in Tibetan as the Pakpa Chakna Dorje Gö Ngönpo Chen Zhéja Jigtén Sum Dulwé Gyü. It belongs to the class of tantric texts and concerns the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi, the powerful wielder of the thunderbolt, who here appears in his blue-garmented form as a master capable of taming the three worlds of gods, humans, and other beings. The text opens with the Buddha dwelling in a celestial palace to the north of Mount Meru, where he enters a samādhi called "Taming the Three Worlds" and emanates rays of three-colored light from the maṇḍala at his heart, addressing an immeasurable assembly with words of reassurance. This text is Toh 501 in the Kangyur, catalogued among the tantric scriptures of the Tibetan Buddhist canon.

In the language of India:
Ārya-Vajrapāṇi-nīlāmbara-dhara-triloka-vinaya-nāma-tantra. In the language of Tibet: The noble tantra called "Vajrapāṇi Wearing the Blue Garment: Taming the Three Worlds."

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling in the northern direction from Mount Meru, in the Palace of the Grove of Willows. He declared to an assembly of gods, humans, and asuras and other worldly beings beyond reckoning, and to the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi and the others: "Sons of good family, do not be afraid. Do not be frightened. Do not be terrified."

Then the Blessed One entered meditative absorption into the samādhi called "Taming the Three Worlds," and from the auspicious maṇḍala at his heart there shone rays of light composed of three colors. From those three-colored rays, many hundreds of thousands of myriads of light-beams were scattered throughout the three worlds, gathering everything together and illuminating all once more with that radiance, and he declared:

Oṃ vajra caṇḍa paca duṣṭānta ka hana daha paca hūṃ phaṭ. Nāga-vidāraṇāya phaṭ. Tiryag-vidāraṇāya phaṭ. Preta-vidāraṇāya phaṭ. Nara-vidāraṇāya phaṭ.

Naraka-vidāraṇāya phaṭ. Deva-vidāraṇāya phaṭ.

Upon these words, the bodies of all beings throughout the three worlds were burst open, and their minds came to rest like crystal spheres. The minds then abided in the likeness of three syllables:

Oṃ is three faces and six hands.

Āḥ is one face and two hands.

Hūṃ is stripped of all ornament.

These are the three families arisen.

Then, having become the three families, this was proclaimed as the proclamation of purpose:

How wondrous — most difficult to find!

The one whose very nature is great aversion,

Vajrapāṇi, so hard to encounter —

we shall attain him now.

Then the king who holds the vajra declared this mantra to arouse the heart of Vajrapāṇi, the chief of the retinue: Vajrapāṇi hṛdayaṃ da.

Then the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi offered this praise to the Blessed One:

Tadyathā: bho bho vānāga adhipataye, idaṃ nīlāmbara-dhara-śarīraṃ, vajrapāṇi hṛdayaṃ, yasmāti kramath'uttsādanaṃ bhaviṣyati.

When this praise was offered, twelve transformations and eighteen omens occurred. All the gods, humans, and other beings arriving from other world-realms were struck with awe and cried out: "We take refuge in the Three Jewels!" The Blessed Ones dwelling in those other world-realms spoke to their own respective disciples: "Do not be afraid. This is an omen of praise to the World-Knowing One, for the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi is dwelling in the world-realm called Endurance."

Then those of the various retinues who were endowed with faith besought their own World-Knowing Ones: "World-Knowing One, we pray that you would grant permission for us to go and see that bodhisattva." And then the various retinues, each grasping hold of the light of their own Teacher, came to the Palace of the Grove of Willows atop Mount Meru, each accompanied by their own assemblies.

Then, having made every offering to the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi and offered praise, they declared:

Having come here at the wondrous omen
of praise to the bodhisattva —
we pray to be told of what is rare to arise in the world,
setting it forth fully and following it through to the end.

Then the Blessed One entered meditative absorption into the samādhi called
"Vajra of Samaya" and performed the empowerment (abhiṣeka), declaring:
"Abhiṣiṅga" — and thereby rendered all present into proper vessels.

This concludes the first chapter, the introductory chapter, of the tantra called
"Taming the Three Worlds."

Then the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi made every offering to the Blessed One, the
Vajra-Holder, circumambulated him three times, prostrated again and again,
and offered this prayer:

For the benefit of all sentient beings,
the supreme among all protections —
Vajrapāṇi's tantra of protection:
may the one whose chief aspect is aversion now teach it.

Then the Teacher, the Vajra-Holder,
the foremost, the ocean of all aversion,
blazing and fierce, with wide-open eyes,
spoke and declared these words:

In the center of a lunar maṇḍala
draw Vajrapāṇi.

Around the border place twenty-four marks.

At the very center write "Sarvaduṣṭaṃ,"
and the first section requires eighteen elements.

Write the name at the hub of the central mark,
and those are to surround the central Vajrapāṇi
with a mantra of praise encircling the middle Vajrapāṇi.

The twenty-four vajras are to be encircled with a nāga-taming mantra.

Then the Blessed One, the Vajra-Holder, entered meditative absorption into
the samādhi called "Taming the Nāgas" and declared this vidyā mantra spoken
by buddhas as numerous as the sands of the Ganges:

Tadyathā — buddha buddha, vi-buddha vi-buddha, mahī-prāpta, hara hara
nāgānāṃ, prahara prahara nāgānāṃ, chinda chinda nāga-hṛdayāni, bhinda
bhinda nāga-marmāṇi, viśīryantū nāga-śarīrāṇi, visphōṭaya.

By this mantra the nāgas were terrified and made ready to flee to their own abodes, but when he declared "nāgayanāni," their bodies became motionless. Then, taking refuge in the Three Jewels, they departed each to their own place.

For the outer Vajrapāṇi,
encircle it with a mantra of gods and spirits.
Both are adorned with the black of the family,
complete with ornaments and the full array of dress.
From the center outward, in due sequence,
write Oṃ and Hūṃ at the border, along with the mantra of Pāṇi,
and draw him holding a rosary.
Mark the vajra at the navel with Oṃ,
and mark the tongue of wisdom with Hūṃ.
On the outer iron mountains
also write skillful means and wisdom.
The vajra to be accomplished place at the navel-hub,
and draw it with saffron.
From the eighth day of the waxing moon,
having drawn it, beginning that same evening,
perform the approach practice until the fourteenth.
On the evening of the fifteenth, accomplish the rite:
in the maṇḍala with its full vestments,
kneel with one knee upon a divine mat
and generate the visualization according to the ritual.
Purify the wheels with incense,
then meditate on the wheels as emptiness.
From emptiness a Hūṃ arises,
and from that Hūṃ melting, a vajra —
marked at its navel-hub as Vajrapāṇi.
From the emanation and gathering of light-rays from it,
generate the body of Vajrapāṇi.
Mark its heart with a lunar vajra.
From the Hūṃ marked at the vajra-navel,
rays of light stream forth and draw in a blue garment.
To that offer varied offerings.
Having performed praise and the sevenfold rite,
draw back the light-rays
and dissolve them into the vajra-Hūṃ at one's own heart.

To that make varied offerings and praises.
Conceive that from the vajras arises gnosis-fire,
the vajra melts,
and it transforms into the form of a wheel.
The body is the form of body,
the marks are in the form of marks.
Roll up that ground — the Kīrti —
and insert the wheel into what is burned.

Then the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi offered this praise:

In order to benefit all sentient beings,
the Teacher, the all-pervading Vajra-Holder —
the protection-wheel that tames all who are difficult to tame
is wondrous and great.

This concludes the second chapter, "Taming What Is Below the Earth," from the tantra called "Taming the Three Worlds."

Then the Vajrapāṇis of the world-realm of Akaniṣṭha made every offering to the Blessed One, the Vajra-Holder, prostrated, and offered this prayer:

Then, the heart of all mantras gathered in one,
for the benefit of all sentient beings —
may the Teacher, the glorious Vajra-Holder,
now teach the cutting vidyā mantra.

Then the Teacher, the cutting vidyā —

He spoke, declaring these words:

First, the approach practice is to be performed. A blue stūpa is to be constructed, and a cloth painting and similar images are to be drawn. In order to purify the obscurations of the tongue, confession is to be made with the Hundred-Syllable mantra. Then the four divine abodes (brahmavihāras) are to be cultivated. From emptiness, these three — having been thoroughly transformed at their extremities — become vajra. That is designated as Vajrapāṇi. Deities are to be emanated and drawn back upon the mantra at the navel-center. Having done so, one becomes Vajrapāṇi. The deity's body-color, ornaments, and so forth are to be known from the root tantra.

From the śrīvatsa at one's own heart-center, rays of light are emitted, gathering the Blessed One. From the tip of the second ray of light, the ten

forms of offering are emanated, and the assembly of the Blessed One is to be offered to. Then, having made proper praise, the third ray of light is directed into the heart-center. The emblem at the heart — the lunar disc — dissolves. In the center abides the twenty-one-fold vajra. Around this, the king of mantras is to be encircled.

The mantra is explained in four aspects: name, meaning, extension, and recitation — these are the four aspects. The recitation is celebrated in this tantra as being of sixteen kinds. The recitation of vajra, the recitation of jewel and lotus, and the recitations of action — these four — each have the nature of the four activities. There is the recitation of the intrinsic nature of vajra, the recitation of fierce action and the cord tantra, the recitation of the fire-sickle wheel, the recitation of arrow and serpent, the recitation of cessation, the recitation of body-protection and command-obedience, the recitation of the all-pervading lance and the bow of Brahmā, and the recitation resembling a lamp.

The characteristic mark of recitation by its very nature is this: constantly, when the gods perform empowerment with a vase, or when one who has reached eight years of age appears, or when a blue flower appears — if none of these occur, the approach practice is to be performed in accordance with the appropriate time. Then the accomplishment practice is to be commenced.

The maṇḍala is explained as being of four kinds: peaceful, enriching, magnetizing, and wrathful. Here, the wrathful is paramount. The maṇḍala is to be entered into as a practice. The guru is to be understood in five aspects. While one adorns oneself with the ornaments, one gazes toward the eastern direction. The extraction is performed through three ritual procedures. The śrīvatsa petition becomes vajra. In the center of the maṇḍala, at its very navel-point, the Blessed One is to be generated in accordance with the ritual. The wisdom-being (jñānasattva) is invited, and through the śrīvatsa petition it becomes wisdom. The outermost portion, like a star by its very nature — the śrīvatsa with HŪṂ — and from the heart-center of the wisdom-being, the wheel of mantras is to be set in rotation. In the center of that, the object of accomplishment is placed. From HŪṂ, a phurba (ritual dagger) is generated, and it is to rest upon that one's tongue. With black bdellium incense, smoke is to be wafted in through that one's nose. The king of mantras, having been placed at the NĀGA syllable, is to be inserted with MĀ RA ZI HA. That is to be inserted into the skull of the evil-natured one, and pressed down beneath a stūpa. Above that, the three-poison heads — OM ĀḤ HŪṂ — with a single

white ribbon made into a phurba, are to be inserted in the first stage. Above that, at the fifth stage, great flesh and the other four — HŪṂ TRĀṂ HRĪḤ Ā A — are to be inserted into the mouth of a raven. At the fourth stage, the wheel is to be inserted. From YAM comes wind, and from RAM comes fire. Above that, draw a wheel with eight spokes. Above that the sun and moon. At the hub at the center of the wheel, draw the head of the enemy facing downward. On that one's chest, the name is written. The eight spokes of the wheel are to be encircled with mantra. The name is taught together with HŪṂ as the object of accomplishment. The two activities below are also drawn. Into skulls of hawk, jackal, and the like, effigies are inserted, sprinkled with white mustard, and pressed down beneath oneself. With black bdellium incense, smoke is wafted in through that one's nose.

An acacia stake, four finger-widths long —
with the driving mantra, strike it into the tongue.
With vajra crossmarks,
seal up that one's openings.

On the day of the Fish and elemental spirits,
urge on the stake and beat with white mustard.

Then those who hold the knowledge mantra are to recite this declaration expressly:

How wondrous — the Teacher is supremely excellent!
How wondrous — the skillful means too are supremely excellent!
How wondrous — the retinue too is supremely excellent!
Supremely excellent and greatly marvelous!

This is the third chapter, on taming the upper earth, from the tantra called Taming the Three Worlds.

Then, the Blessed One Vajrapāṇi, who had come from another world-realm, together with his retinue, offered worship and prostrations and made this request:

This wheel of the rite of slaying —
that it may tame what is upon the earth —
may the Great Vajra One please expound it.

Then the Teacher, Vajrapāṇi — the Vajra-Holder — spoke these words:

Those who revile the vajra master
and who abandon the Great Vehicle

are to be gathered in by the rite of gathering.
But if they cannot be brought under control,
one is to meditate on all sentient beings of the three realms
as having the body of a buddha,
and by that one proclaims the fault of meditating on slaying them.

The Vajra-Holder with three faces and six arms
sends forth emanations from his heart center.
By these, the guardian deities of the world
are drawn in with nooses,

and one recites: OM VAJRA CAṆḌA SARVA DUṢṬAṂ VEŚA JAḤ —
and with weapons one cuts, and so on:
OM VAJRA CAṆḌA SARVA DUṢṬĀṂ TAKA HANA DAHA PACA HŪṂ PHAṬ.

Having done a hundred thousand recitations of the nāga mantra,
on the day of the Fish and elemental spirits,
adorn oneself with ornaments
and guard with substances and mantras.

At midnight, at a crossroads shrine,
recite the king of mantras.

Then draw the wheel.

The outer ring and inner ring are to be drawn with poisonwood,
with a joyful and wholesome mind.

Use fine unblemished cloth with supreme saffron.

In the center, for Vajrapāṇi,

on the forehead, heart, and navel,

arrange the three syllables for the three bodies —

draw them complete with ornaments and attire.

Throughout the surrounding ring write DUṢṬAṂ.

At the feet, the crown, the right and left,

at the center the sun and moon,

draw the emblems of the four kings.

At the four corners, HŪṂ upon vajra seats.

On the surrounding ring, wisdom and skillful means.

From HŪṂ, the pledge being (samaya-sattva):

invite the wisdom being, make offering, and request the dissolution.

In the lower ring, a black frog with five limbs —
into its heart, and making six in all, insert the name and clan.
At the four directions on the spokes, skulls at the four corners.
On the spokes and on the skulls, the name and clan.
Surround the two rings with hymns of praise.

From HRĪḤ in the frog's mouth light streams forth,
summoning the earth lords and great nāgas; make offering.
Offering substances: milk and so on.

Then summon the one to be liberated.
The one who abides properly in body, speech, and mind —
dissolve them into the name and clan and leave them there.
From the skull, generate the demon from HŪṢ.
Properly make the application to that.
To the nāgas, bind them with the sacred bond and make offering.
With the phurba, cut off the four directions and corners.
If drawn in the lower direction, the rite succeeds.

Then those making supplication recite this declaration in wonder:

How marvelous — that among all phenomena
there is the essential nature of non-conceptuality!
How marvelous — that while all phenomena are pure in their intrinsic nature,
it can yet be spoken of even at the conventional level!

Then the assembly who had been present from the beginning, together with
the Teacher who had come from another world-realm and his retinue — the
Blessed One Vajrapāṇi, arising from the level of the summit, entered into the
meditative absorption called Averting All Harm. Having recited OM VAJRAPĀṆI
HRDAYA, he roused the mind of the Teacher who had come from another
realm, together with his retinue, and declared:

TADYATHĀ: HŪṢ PHAṬ. NĀGAVIDĀRAṆĀYA PHAṬ. NĀGOTṢĀDANĀYA PHAṬ.
NĪLĀMBASANĀYA PHAṬ. APRATIHAṬAPARĀKRAMĀYA PHAṬ. KṚTĀNTĀYA PHAṬ.
KṚTĀNTARŪPĀYA PHAṬ. ROṢAṆĀYA PHAṬ. TRĀSANĀYA PHAṬ.
KUMBHAṆḌOTṢĀDANĀYA PHAṬ. PRETAPIŚĀCAVINĀŚAKARĀYA PHAṬ.
YAKṢĀPASMĀRAVINĀŚAKARĀYA PHAṬ. HASA HASA. DĀRA DĀRA. MĀRAYA
MĀRAYA.

NĀŚAYA NĀŚAYA. SARVAVIG HNĀN VINĀŚAKARĀYA PHAṬ. SARVAŚATRŪN
SAṂGHAVINĀŚAKARĀYA PHAṬ. NĪLĀMBARADHARA VAJRAPĀṆI RĀJÑĀPAYATI

SVĀHĀ.

The moment these words were spoken, the retinue from the other realm was struck with terror. And they cried out in verses of astonishment:

How wondrous, the Teacher's great blessing!

How wondrous, the great power of mantra!

How wondrous, the great afflictions of the mighty ones —
yet the retinue abides in perfect equanimity.

This is the fourth chapter of the Tantra of Taming the Three Worlds, the chapter on taming those upon the earth.

Then the three worlds of the Endurance realm together with the three worlds that had come from other world-systems made offerings and praises to the Blessed One Vajrapāṇi, and each departed to their own abode.

Vajrapāṇi then declared to the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi: "Receive and uphold this tantra, which was spoken by all the buddhas of the past. Bear it well!"

This is the fifth chapter, the chapter of complete entrustment.

The Tantra of Taming the Three Worlds is complete.

Translated by the Indian master Dīpaṃkara together with the great-translation monk Rinchen Zangpo, the chief Lotsāwa.

Translator's Notes

- The Sanskrit title Ārya-Vajrapāṇi-nīlāmbara-dhara-triloka-vinaya is rendered literally: "Noble Vajrapāṇi, Wearer of the Blue Garment, Taming the Three Worlds." The term "nīlāmbara-dhara" specifically identifies Vajrapāṇi in his fierce blue-garbed form associated with this tantra.

The mantra strings are left in their Sanskrit phonetic form as is standard for liturgical mantras; the "vidāraṇā" sequences mean "the splitting apart of" nāgas, animals, pretas, humans, hell-beings, and gods respectively.

The phrase "great aversion" in the verse of proclamation renders "zheshdang chenpo" (aversion/anger, Skt. dveṣa) intentionally: Vajrapāṇi in his wrathful form embodies the transformation of great anger into wrathful wisdom, which is the doctrinal point of the verse.

"Endurance" renders Mi-mjed (Skt. Sahā), the standard name for our world-system, literally "the world that is to be endured."

The verse section describing the three syllables and three families presents the seed-syllables Om, Āḥ, and Hūṃ as corresponding to the three buddha families (Body, Speech, and Mind, or alternatively Buddha, Lotus, and Vajra families) — a standard Vajrayāna doctrinal schema.

- The phrase rendered "the one whose chief aspect is aversion" translates a verse identifying the deity's wrathful, aversion-natured form as principal. This is doctrinally standard for the wrathful Vajrapāṇi tantra context, where aversion transmuted is the chief energy, but the

phrasing is unusual and worth noting.

The term "Kīrti" appears as a proper name or technical label for the ground or surface of the ritual diagram to be "rolled up." Its exact referent in this ritual context is not fully transparent; it may denote a place-name or a specific material substrate. This is a genuine ambiguity.

The mantra syllables are transliterated from the Tibetan phonetic rendering of Sanskrit and are presented as best reconstruction; minor variations from canonical Sanskrit recensions are possible.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, as this appears to be a chapter boundary leading into the next section.

- The passage is a densely technical sādhana-instruction section of a wrathful tantra, mixing second-person imperatives with descriptive enumeration. Several mantra-syllables (NĀGA BOR, MĀ RA ZI HA, the seed-syllables YAṂ, RAṂ, HŪṂ, TRĀṂ, HRĪḤ, Ā, A) are transliterated as they stand; their precise ritual meaning is intentionally opaque to the uninitiated and is not elaborated in the source text. The phrase "twenty-one-fold vajra" (二十一度母) refers to a specific iconographic form whose details would be given in the root tantra. The "cord tantra" (索索索索索索索索) is a reference to a related subsidiary tantra whose identity is not specified in this passage.
- The phrase rendered as "on the day of the Fish and elemental spirits" refers to an astral or calendrical designation used in tantric ritual timing; "Fish" likely indicates a lunar mansion or day-sign, and "elemental spirits" a class of beings associated with a particular time period. The precise calendrical system is not entirely recoverable from the passage alone.

The term rendered "the one to be liberated" is a technical euphemism in wrathful tantric ritual for the adversarial being who is dispatched through the rite — liberation here carrying the sense of forcible transference of consciousness rather than soteriological liberation in the ordinary sense.

The mantra epithet KṚTĀNTA and KṚTĀNTARŪPA refer to a deity resembling Yama, the lord of death, invoked here in his wrathful function; the translation preserves the Sanskrit directly as is conventional for dhāraṇī syllables.

- The text addresses "the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi" as a recipient of Vajrapāṇi's own instruction, which reflects the convention in tantric literature of the deity speaking to his bodhisattva form or a named disciple bearing the same name. The phrase rendered "Receive and uphold" translates two verbs meaning literally "take to heart" and "bear or carry," a standard formula for dharma transmission. The Indian master Dīpaṃkara here is almost certainly Dīpaṃkaraśrījñāna, known in Tibet as Atiśa, and the Lotsāwa Rinchen Zangpo was his famous translation collaborator, active in the late tenth and early eleventh centuries.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.